as many as 102 lions in the first decade of his rule. At Beital-Wali in Lower Nubia, a tame lioness is shown near the throne of Rameses II (1290–1224) with an inscription ‘Slayer of his Enemies’. Five centuries later, the court records of the Assyrian king Ashurabanipal II (884–859 BC) recount:

> The gods Nemruta and Negral, who love my priesthood, gave me the wild animals of the plains, commanding me to hunt. Thirty elephants I trapped and killed, 257 great wild oxen I brought down with my weapons, attacking from my chariots, 370 lions I killed with my hunting spears.

The lion is also represented in a multitude of sculptures, friezes and paintings in Ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia. The Sumerian goddess Nana, the Assyrian goddess Ishtar and the Persian goddess Anahita are all associated with the lion and sometimes depicted riding the lion—rather like the Hindu goddess Durga. It is obvious that the lion was an important animal in art, culture, royal symbolism and religion in the Middle East from a very early period. Why were the Harappans so lukewarm to an animal with such obvious charms?

The most likely reason is that the lion was not common in the subcontinent till after the collapse of the Harappan civilization. This should not be surprising. Before 2000 BC, north-west India was much wetter than it is today with higher rainfall and the Saraswati river flowing. The lion is an animal that hunts in open grasslands and could not penetrate the tiger-infested jungles that existed in the region. However, the balance shifted as the climate became drier and the Saraswati dwindled. There would have been a savannah phase when lions from Iran could have made their way through Balochistan and then into tiger territory, which would explain why the earliest artifact depicting a lion in the subcontinent, a golden goblet, was found in Balochistan. As Harappan urban centers were abandoned and populations migrated to the Gangetic plains, the lions would have taken over the wilderness. Over time they would penetrate as far east as Bihar and northwestern Orissa, co-existing in many places with tigers. Eastern and southern India, nevertheless, remained the exclusive domain of the tiger.

Interestingly, the Rig Veda does mention the animal although it accords it far less importance than the horse or the bull. This poses the obvious